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INPUT FOR THE OFFICE OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY POLICY ON THE DEVELOPMENT OF AN ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE ACTION PLAN

A BRIEF COMPLETED BY **FOR EVERY CHILD**, A STUDENT-LED ORGANIZATION THAT FOCUSES ON COMBATTING THE BIGGEST THREATS TO CHILDREN

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Executive Summary

This policy brief explores the evolving landscape of AI development, by highlighting the ethical concerns and risks posed by AI misuse in the weaponization of information. Additionally, this brief explores ethical lapses in data and resource utilization, and the persuasive spread of misinformation on unregulated social media. Finally, this brief covers how these challenges can be addressed while positioning the United States as a global leader in AI innovation.

While the U.S. must remain at the forefront of AI technologies, the pace of development outstrips current regulatory frameworks. To manage both the opportunities and dangers posed by AI, the creation of a White House AI Commission or Council is recommended to provide a clear path for policy, regulation, and national collaboration. This body would oversee AI development to ensure that innovation continues in a manner that maximizes benefits for the economy and society, while also mitigating risks such as misinformation, exploitation of vulnerable populations, and environmental degradation.

Key Findings Include:

AI Exploitation of Child Vulnerability: Unregulated social media platforms enable the rapid spread of misinformation targeting children. Malicious figures have exploited these spaces to manipulate young minds, distort perceptions, and influence behavior particularly on climate change and public health. With AI evolving faster than regulations, children face growing risks. These risks include AI-driven disinformation, deepfakes, and manipulative content designed to exploit their vulnerabilities.

Ethical and Environmental Impacts: Large-Scale AI models – such as ChatGPT – demand substantial water and energy resources. The computational power required for training and running these models places a significant strain on environmental sustainability. These systems require high energy consumption which contributes to carbon emissions, and use a vast amount of water for cooling AI data centers. This further exacerbates resource scarcity in already water-stressed regions.

Key Alternatives and Recommendation:

Alternative One: Sustainable AI Development and Resource Accountability

To off put the environmental strain of AI, policy makers mandate sustainability standards for AI development. This could include the prioritization of renewable energy sources, designing more resource sufficient AI models, and requiring tech firms to disclose their energy and water consumption.

Alternative Two: Child Centric AI safeguards

Implement targeted regulatory measures to prevent the weaponization of AI against children. This includes enforcing specific content filters on digital platforms, and establishing the rapid response protocols to remove harmful AI generative content such as defects that target children. Additionally, integrating digital literacy programs into school curricula can empower younger users to recognize and counteract manipulative content.

Alternative Three: Enforceable AI regulations With Public Environmental Protections

Rather than merely reacting to AI-related harms, policymakers should take a proactive approach. Governments should implement legally binding accountability measures to ensure AI development aligns with ethical and public safety standards. This includes creating enforceable liability frameworks that hold companies responsible for AI-generated harm, from misinformation to environmental damage.

Final + Main recommendation: Establishment of a White House AI Commission or Council

Establish a White House AI Commission or Council that would focus on ensuring U.S. leadership in AI while balancing ethical and environmental concerns. This commission would work to ensure enforceable regulations that hold AI developers accountable for harmful outcomes such as misinformation, and environmental harm.

Summary

As AI continues to shape society, its governance must evolve to protect public interest while encouraging innovation. Without enforceable regulations, AI's unchecked expansion risks seeping social and environmental inequalities. By implementing robust accountability frameworks, sustainability mandates, and child centric protections, policymakers can ensure AI serves as a tool for progress rather than exploitation. The development of the AI Action Plan presents a pivotal opportunity to establish lasting safeguards that prioritize ethical responsibility, public trust, and environmental sustainability.

Background

Artificial intelligence has emerged as a transformative technology across multiple sectors — from healthcare and education to defense and environmental management. Historically, advancements in AI have been lauded for their potential to revolutionize industries; however, this progress has also raised ethical and environmental concerns. For instance, training large language models (LLM) like ChatGPT requires substantial energy and water resources. A factor often overlooked in broad discussions of digital transformation. Furthermore, social media platforms — which are largely unregulated — have become hot beds for climate misinformation, undermining efforts to communicate critical data about the environment.

This brief is situated within a complex policy landscape that includes multiple stakeholders, such as national federal agencies like the [EPA](#) and NIST. The imperative is clear: develop an AI framework that not only encourages innovation, but also mitigates adverse impacts on youth and the environment.

Child Safety Concerns Regarding AI

AI Exploitation of Child Vulnerability

The rapid evolution of artificial intelligence presents a complex landscape of opportunities and risks. Two interrelated issues stand out: the exploitation of child vulnerability via unregulated social media platforms, and the considerable ethical and environmental impact of large-scale AI systems. Unregulated social media platforms have become conduits for rapidly disseminating false and misleading information aimed directly at children. Malicious figures are within these unprotected digital spaces to manipulate young minds, skew, public perceptions, and influence behavior, particularly in critical areas, such as climate change awareness in public health.

Meanwhile, the rapid pace of AI development has outpaced current regulatory frameworks, leaving children increasingly vulnerable to harmful practices. These vulnerabilities include the weaponization of AI to deliver manipulative content, orchestrate online scams, and launch tailored disinformation campaigns that specifically exploit their development weaknesses.

Echo Chambers and Algorithmic Bias

Social media platforms have become epicenters for the rapid dissemination of misinformation, deepfake content, and polarizing narratives. Driven by algorithms optimized for [engagement rather than accuracy](#), these platforms create echo chambers that expose young users to disoriented narratives on topics such as climate change, public health, and political events. Pupils are not only sharing conspiracy theories but are also increasingly influenced by highly manipulated content, which highlights the urgent need for both regulatory intervention and robust digital literacy programs. These systems repeatedly curate feeds with sensational and polarizing material. This phenomenon, well-documented in academic literature, results in [echo chambers](#) where young users, who's critical thinking skills are still developing, are repeatedly exposed to the same disordered narratives.

Deepfakes and AI Generated Misinformation

The rise of deepfake technology has added a dangerous dimension to digital misinformation. A [deepfake](#) is a synthetic media — such as an image, video, or audio recording — created using artificial intelligence to realistically replace someone’s likeness or voice with another. Advanced AI methods now allow for the creation of hyper-realistic videos and images that are virtually indistinguishable from authentic media. Malicious actors can easily exploit these tools to generate fake news, [non-consensual explicit material](#), and politically manipulate context. AI-generated revenge porn – an early form of deepfake misuse – [signals a broader risk](#) to political discourse, personal privacy, and safety. As deepfakes become more accessible, the ability to differentiate genuine content from manipulated media becomes increasingly challenging, thereby eroding public trust in legitimate information sources.

Regulatory Gaps and Economic Incentives

One of the core challenges lies in the regulatory gap: as AI technologies and deepfake capabilities evolve rapidly, legislative frameworks have lagged behind. As of now, there are [no comprehensive federal laws](#) in the U.S. specifically prohibiting the creation or distribution of deepfake, leaving a legal void that allows for the potential misuse of AI technology. Social media companies, [driven by profit](#) and high engagement metrics, have little incentive to overhaul algorithms that promote sensational content – even if that content is misleading or harmful. The current profit-driven model of these platforms further incentivizes the spread of false narratives. Without robust oversight, these companies continue to operate in a way that prioritizes revenue over public safety, leaving young and impressionable users exposed to persistent misinformation.

Impact of Weaponization of AI and Social Media

A particularly alarming trend is the weaponization of AI combined with social media’s vast reach. Malicious actors are now leveraging AI technologies – such as deepfake generation to intentionally craft disinformation campaigns that are tailored to manipulate public opinion and polarize communities. Coordinated deepfake videos can be designed to discredit political figures or fabricate evidence that incites social unrest. This weaponization of AI is not merely a byproduct of technological advancement; it is a strategic effort to undermine democratic processes and destabilize societal trust. The rapid proliferation of such manipulated content creates a pervasive climate of uncertainty, making it difficult for citizens, especially young users, to trust any digital media. The economic structure of social media platforms further exacerbates this threat, as sensational content designed to provoke strong emotional reactions is more likely to go viral and generate profit. The combined effects of advanced AI weaponization and algorithmic bias thus pose a dual threat; not only is the truth distorted, but the very foundations of a reliable public discourse are at risk.

In summary, the convergence of unregulated social media practices, algorithmic bias, and the rapid advancement of deepfake technology creates a dangerous environment for young users.

Evidence from multiple studies shows that these platforms are fostering echo chambers that limit diverse perspectives, while deepfakes further blur the line between reality and manipulation. Coupled with legal gaps and economic incentives that favor sensational content the result is an alarming increase in misinformation and a weaponized information environment. Addressing these issues requires immediate policy interventions — ranging from stricter regulatory oversight to the integration of digital literacy programs in education — to safeguard the next generation and preserve the integrity of public discourse.

Environmental Concerns of AI

The rapid advancement of artificial intelligence has introduced significant ethical and environmental challenges that necessitate comprehensive analysis and action. A critical concern is the substantial environmental footprint of large-scale AI systems, particularly regarding their energy and water consumption.

Training and deploying AI models demand considerable computational resources, leading to high energy consumption and carbon emissions. Data centers, which form the backbone of AI operations, currently consume about [2% of global electricity](#). This energy demand is projected to rise as AI technologies become more prevalent. Moreover these facilities require vast amounts of water for cooling purposes, exacerbating water scarcity issues in various regions. The [United Nations Environment Programme](#) highlights that data centers are significant consumers of water and electricity, contributing to environmental degradation.

Recent developments underscore the urgency of addressing AI's environmental impact. Utilities in the United States are planning to construct new [natural gas-fired](#) power plants to meet the escalating energy demands of AI data centers. For instance, projects by tech giants like [Microsoft, Meta, and Amazon](#) involve significant investments in natural gas infrastructure, raising concerns about increased carbon emissions and reliance on fossil fuels.

However, some experts argue that the perceived energy crisis associated with AI may be overstated. While AI companies express concerns about energy shortages, data center energy demand is growing but is not likely to push electrify demands to a critical point. The U.S has consistently [produced more energy](#) than it consumes, and a significant portion of new electricity capacity is expected to come from renewable sources. Therefore, the narrative that AI development necessitates increased fossil fuel production may be driven more by political and economic interests than by actual energy requirements.

Sustainable AI Practices:

To mitigate these environmental challenges, several strategies are being explored:

- **Energy-Efficient Hardware:** Developing and developing hardware optimized for energy efficiency can significantly reduce the power requirements of AI systems. Innovation in chip design and cooling technologies are pivotal in this endeavor. For example, [NVIDIA](#) has introduced liquid-cooled GPUs that allow data centers to cool systems more effectively than traditional air conditioning, consuming less power and water.
- **Renewable Energy Integration:** Powering data centers with renewable energy sources, such as wind and solar, can offset carbon emissions associated with AI operation. Companies are increasingly investing in renewable energy projects to support their data centers. Brookfield Asset Management, for instance, has committed up to [€20 billion](#) to develop AI infrastructure in France, focusing on digitalization and clean power.

Regulatory and Economic Implications

The environmental ramifications of AI have prompted calls for stricter regulations and sustainable practices. The United States, the [Environmental Protection Agency](#) emphasizes the importance of sustainability across industries, advocating for practices that minimize environmental impact. Economically, while AI offers substantial benefits, the long-term costs associated with environmental degradation could outweigh immediate gains. Therefore, integrating sustainability into AI development is not only an ethical imperative but also an economic necessity.

Addressing the environmental impact of AI requires a multifaceted approach that combines technological innovation, regulatory oversight, and a commitment to sustainability. By adopting energy-efficient practices, investing in renewable energy, and designing optimized data centers, the AI industry can mitigate its environmental footprint, ensuring that technological progress does not come at the expense of our planet's health.

Policy Recommendations

Recommendation One: Sustainable AI Development and resource accountability

The environmental impact of AI is profound, with large-scale models requiring immense computational power and significant resources for cooling data centers. Operations of these centers already consume vast amounts of energy, with some data centers using as much [electricity as small cities](#). Google reported a [20% increase](#) in water consumption since 2022. As AI continues to advance, this strain on global energy supplies will only intensify. To counteract these effects, sustainability standards that ensure AI development is conducted responsibly must be implemented. A key component of this strategy is prioritizing renewable energy sources. On February 10, 2025, [Brookfield Asset Management](#) announced a €20 billion investment program in AI infrastructure powered by clean energy, proving that a sustainable transition is both possible and economically viable.

In addition to energy concerns, AI models demand [vast amounts of water cooling](#), exacerbating water scarcity in already vulnerable regions. The substantial water consumption of AI data centers poses significant challenges, particularly for low-income communities in water scarce regions. These facilities often require millions of gallons of water daily for cooling purposes. For instance, a single data center can consume up to [5 million gallons](#) of potable water per day, sufficient to supply thousands of households or farms. The environmental impact extends beyond water usage.

Research has shown that data centers contribute to [air pollution](#), which disproportionately affects low-income communities because of how close they can be to data centers. This pollution can lead to adverse health effects, exacerbating existing social inequalities. There's an urgent need for resource-efficient AI models. The development of algorithms that optimize computations while minimizing e-usage must be enforced. Currently, few companies disclose their energy and water consumption making it difficult to assess AI's true environmental impact. Policies that mandate data center efficiency and require public reporting of energy usage, allow policymakers to make informed regulatory decisions. Without such measures, AI's rapid expansion could become a major driver of global resource depletion and environmental degradation.

Recommendation Two: Child Centric AI Safeguards

Children are particularly vulnerable to the negative effects of AI-driven misinformation and exploration. Digital platforms, powered by engagement-driven algorithms, often expose young users to harmful or manipulative content. The children's internet protection act has attempted to address this issue by requiring schools and libraries to implement content filters, yet manages go unprotected. A critical component of safeguarding children involves the establishment of rapid resounds protocols to remove harmful AI-generated content.

Recently, companies like Roblox, Discord, OpenAi, and Google have collaborated to develop robust open online safety tools or [ROOST](#). ROOST is an initiative aimed at providing AI-powered content moderation solutions. Voluntary corporate initiatives are not sufficient. The establishment of legally binding protocols that require digital platforms to detect and remove harmful content targeted at children in real-time is needed.

Furthermore, integrating digital literacy programs into schools curricula is essential for equipping children with the skills necessary to identify and counteract manipulative AI-generated content. Without proactive intervention, AI-powered misinformation will continue to exploit the developmental vulnerabilities of children, shaping their perception and influencing their behavior in ways that could have long-term societal consequences.

Recommendation Three: Enforceable AI Regulations with Public Environmental Protections

Rather than adopting a reactive stance toward AI-related harms, policymakers must shift from a reactive to a proactive approach by implementing a comprehensive regulatory framework that ensures AI development aligns with ethical, environmental, and public safety standards. This framework would consist of federal policies that mandate transparency, fairness, and accountability in AI systems. For example, AI companies could be required to disclose their algorithms, resource usage, and environmental impact, ensuring that their technologies comply with established ethical guidelines. A legally binding system of accountability would establish clear consequences for companies that violate these standards. If a company's AI system causes harm – whether through misinformation, privacy violations, or environmental damage – it could face penalties such as fines, suspension of operations, or legal action. These penalties would encourage responsible development and deployment, ensuring that AI systems serve the public interests while minimizing harm.

A crucial aspect of AI regulation is establishing liability frameworks that hold tech firms accountable for AI-related damages, such as misinformation, privacy violations, and environmental costs. Federal agencies like the FTC and DOJ could enforce regulations, while an independent AI oversight body could monitor compliance and impose penalties. AI-related damages should be added based on the harm caused, such as economic losses from biased algorithms or environmental impact from excessive resource use. For example, companies responsible for deepfakes or discriminatory AI systems should be held liable. Clear legal responsibility ensures companies prioritize ethical development, balancing innovation with public welfare.

The long term costs of environmental degradation and societal harm far outweigh the short term economic benefits of unchecked AI growth. By integrating sustainable practices into AI policies, governments can encourage responsible innovation while mitigating the broader environmental risks associated with unsustainable AI practices.

Ultimately, enforceable AI regulation must be designed to balance technological progress with ethical responsibility. Without comprehensive legal frameworks and strict accountability measures, AI's rapid evolution will continue to pose risks to public safety, democratic integrity, and environmental sustainability. The U.S. government must take action to implement legally binding safeguards that ensure AI serves the national interest, addressing societal and environmental challenges within the country.

Final + Main Recommendation: Establishment of a White House AI Commission or Council

The rapid evolution of artificial intelligence (AI) presents unprecedented opportunities for U.S. economic growth, national security, and societal advancement. However, the development and deployment of AI technologies also bring significant challenges—ranging from the spread of misinformation and algorithmic bias to environmental concerns due to immense energy demands. To maintain leadership in this emerging field, the United States must adopt a national framework that balances innovation with ethical and environmental safeguards. A dedicated White House AI Commission or Council, overseeing and guiding AI policy across federal agencies, is essential to achieve this balance.

Why a National AI Commission is Essential

1. Ensuring U.S. Technological Leadership

The United States has long led technological innovation, and AI is now one of the most transformative fields shaping our future. Maintaining a competitive edge in AI is critical for both economic prosperity and national security. Although recent federal actions emphasize the need to [expand domestic AI infrastructure](#), existing regulatory frameworks are struggling to keep pace with rapid advancements. A dedicated national AI Commission would consolidate policy efforts, streamline oversight, and establish a coherent strategy for AI development – ensuring that regulations evolve alongside innovation.

2. Mitigating Ethical and Societal Risks

While AI systems can drive progress, they also pose serious ethical and societal risks. AI-generated misinformation – such as deepfakes – threatens democratic processes and [can manipulate](#) public opinion. Additionally, algorithmic biases can result in discrimination against marginalized communities, exacerbating social inequalities. A national AI Commission would be responsible for formulating clear ethical guidelines and establishing transparency requirements to ensure that AI technologies are developed and deployed in ways that protect civil rights, promote fairness, and prevent harm.

3. Addressing Environmental Challenges

The environmental impact of AI is another critical concern. Large-scale AI models, especially in deep learning, demand enormous computational power that leads to significant energy consumption and water usage. Recent reports have shown that major tech companies are experiencing rising resource demands, which contribute to a growing carbon footprint. For example, Microsoft has faced a [34% increase](#) in water consumption as its data center continues to require more water. The commission would implement strategies — such as mandatory reporting on energy and water usage and requiring

developers to mitigate environmental impacts; to ensure that AI developments support the U.S. climate goals while encouraging innovation.

Core Functions and Mandate

The proposed Commission would have a clear mandate to address both immediate challenges and long-term governance of AI technologies. The core functions of the Commission include:

1. Policy Formulation and Strategic Oversight:

The commission would develop a comprehensive national AI strategy that integrates technological innovation with ethical and environmental considerations. It would set clear guidelines for AI ethics, mandate transparency in AI systems operations, and create a roadmap for integrating AI into critical sectors like healthcare, defense, and public administration. This strategy would ensure that AI deployment aligns with U.S. values and enhances national security.

2. Regulatory Framework and Enforcement:

A critical role of the Commission would be to establish a regulatory framework that holds AI developers accountable for harmful outcomes such as misinformation or biased decision-making. This framework would require rigorous pre-deployment testing, independent third-party audits for high-risk systems, and the imposition of penalties for non-compliance with ethical or safety standards. Such measures would create accountability not currently present in the fast-moving AI industry.

3. Interagency Coordination and Stakeholder Engagement:

Acting as the central coordinating body for AI policy, the Commission would work with key federal agencies—including the Department of Defense, Energy, and the Office of Science and Technology Policy – as well as engage private-sector stakeholders, academic experts, and civil society groups.. This collaboration would ensure that best practices are shared and that policies reflect the diverse perspective and needs of all affected parties.

4. Monitoring and Evaluation:

Given the rapid pace of AI advancements, continuous monitoring and evaluation are crucial. There is a [lack of regulation](#) in regards to AI policy on a federal level. The Commission would track metrics such as energy consumption, Carbon emissions, and safety evaluations of AI systems. Regular assessment would enable the Commission to ensure responsible development and deployment of AI technologies while adapting regulations to emerging challenges.

5. Balancing Innovation and Regulation:

Achieving the right balance between encouraging innovation and imposing necessary safeguards is essential. Over-regulation could stifle creativity and drive innovation overseas, whereas under-regulation might expose society to significant risks. The Commission would adopt a risk-based approach – imposing stringent controls on high-risk AI systems used in critical infrastructure or public safety, while allowing greater flexibility for lower-risk applications. In addition, it would promote voluntary industry partnerships to develop technical standards and best practices, ensuring that regulations remain adaptive and focused on protecting public interest without impeding progress.

6. Accountability for Harmful Outcomes:

Holding AI developers accountable for negative outcomes is crucial for ensuring that AI serves the public good. The Commission would have the authority to enforce penalties for failures to meet established ethical, safety, or environmental standards. It would also require public disclosure of AI system performance metrics, safety evaluations, and resource usage. These measures would build public trust in AI technologies and provide a mechanism for redress when harmful outcomes occur.

Operational Structure and Implementation:

For effective operation, the Commission must be structured to encourage collaboration, accountability, and transparency. Its membership should include representatives from key federal agencies, industry experts, academic researchers, and civil society advocates. A clearly defined mandate, empowered by an executive order, would ensure that the Commission can take decisive action and report regularly to Congress and the public. Transparency and adaptive governance will be key to maintaining public confidence and ensuring that policies evolve with emerging technological challenges.

Anticipated Challenges and Mitigation Strategies:

The creation of a national AI Commission may face challenges such as resistance from industry groups and potential political gridlock. Some Stakeholders may argue that increased regulation could stifle innovation, while others may contend that AI poses minimal risks. The Commission must engage these stakeholders early in the policy development process, emphasizing that its goal is to protect both innovation and public safety. By adopting a flexible, risk-based approach, the Commission can avoid an overly burdensome regulatory framework while focusing on the most pressing concerns.

Summary:

The establishment of a White House AI Commission is critical for ensuring that the United States maintains its leadership in AI while addressing the ethical, societal, and environmental

challenges associated with this rapidly evolving technology. By creating a comprehensive, national strategy for AI governance, the commission would encourage innovation, safeguard public welfare, and protect the environment. With a strong focus on domestic priorities, the Commission would ensure that AI development benefits all Americans, strengthens our democracy, enhances national security, and supports long-term sustainability.

Conclusion:

The rapid advancement of AI presents both unprecedented opportunities and profound risks, particularly in the realms of misinformation, child safety, and environmental sustainability. Unregulated digital platforms – powered by engagement-driven algorithms – expose young users to manipulative content, deepfake misinformation, and echo chambers that distort public perception. Meanwhile, AI's escalating energy and water consumption threaten global sustainability, exacerbating resource scarcity and environmental degradation. These issues demand immediate and enforceable policy interventions. Companies must be held responsible for AI-driven harm, from misinformation to environmental damage. By prioritizing ethical AI development, we can ensure technological progress aligns with public safety, democratic integrity, and environmental sustainability. The time for proactive, enforceable action is now before these challenges become irreversible.

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